



Security Watch

Vulnerabilities in the JRE

The Problem

On February 8, seven vulnerabilities were reported in the Sun JRE (Java Runtime Environment). The following releases are affected by one or more of the seven vulnerabilities on Windows, Solaris, and Linux platforms:

1. JDK and JRE 5.0 Update 5 and prior versions
2. SDK and JRE 1.4.2_09 and prior versions
3. SDK and JRE 1.3.1_16 and prior versions

You might not know what version of the JRE you have installed on your machine. You can find out what version you have by two methods: go to Control Panel > Add or Remove Programs, then scroll down to "J". You should see your version there. Or else, at a command prompt, type in "java -fullversion".

The Damages

The vulnerabilities can be exploited by nasty people to take over a user's system. It's been found that with the affected versions, malicious, untrusted applets can read and write local files or execute local applications.

The Solution

Upgrade. If you have JDK or JRE 5.0 Update 5 or prior installed, the update is available at <http://java.sun.com/j2se/1.5.0/download.jsp>

If you have SDK and JRE 1.4.x, head to <http://java.sun.com/j2se/1.4.2/download.html>
If you have SDK and JRE 1.3.x, head to <http://java.sun.com/j2se/1.3/download.html>

search the contents of one computer from another. Using the optional "Search Across Computers" facility temporarily stores text copies of searchable items on Google's servers for up to 30 days!

"Search Across Computers" makes the usual file types—including Web histories, Office documents, PDF files and text files—searchable from other computers. Users can log on using their Google password to find data on files they've worked on regardless of which PC they used while working on them.

Secure Web pages are excluded from the list of file types, and users can also exclude file types or locations from indexing as they see fit. But privacy activists such as the Electronic Frontier Foundation (EFF) have said the feature "greatly increases the risk to consumer privacy." It describes the tool as a convenient "one-stop-shop for hackers" who've obtained a user's Google password. Users should avoid using Google Desktop 3, the EFF advises. "Unless you configure Google Desktop very carefully—and few people will—Google will have copies of your tax returns, love letters, business records..." EFF Staff Attorney Kevin Bankston said. "The government could then demand these personal files with only a subpoena..."

It's not just the EFF: security experts at

Kaspersky Labs warned that hackers are now more likely to launch phishing attacks in an attempt to obtain users' Google account passwords. "If an attacker can obtain your Google login details they will be able to access your confidential files," the company noted on its blog. Kaspersky Labs, too, has advised users not to use Google Desktop 3.

Google, of course, argues that the growing use of multiple computers by users makes the feature useful. "Too many people are working across multiple computers now," Google vice president Marissa Mayer told USA Today. "This makes their lives easier." And a Google spokeswoman recently said, "Privacy was an important consideration in the development of this feature, and we've taken a number of steps to protect the privacy of our users."

Another chapter in the Search-Engine-To-Big-Brother book...

GETTING PAST THE FILTER

AOL And Yahoo! To Charge For E-Mail

Don't be alarmed—you won't need to pay to send mail through Yahoo! It's about legitimate mass-mailers: the two companies are offering the chance to pay to avoid their spam

HOT

RAM Drives

Why not use RAM as permanent storage? Atomchip (www.atomchip.com) is doing it—memory is much faster than hard disks, and you don't need to wait for programs to load into memory—they're right there!



NOT

The Interface

Current generation memory chips can transfer data at blinding speeds approaching 6 Gbps, but RAM drives today use the SATA II interface, which is capable of only 300 Mbps. What a waste!



filters. By paying between a quarter (11 paise) and one cent (45 paise) per message, companies will get preferential delivery of their messages. So, a "business class" e-mail will go straight to a user's Inbox, marked with a stamp saying something like "Certified E-mail," while a free mail will have to go through the spam filters. Free mails may also have images and Web links removed.

Companies must adhere to a code of practice to send "business class" mail, and AOL and Yahoo! say the system will help them reduce spam and phishing attacks. "We want e-mails sent using the technology to have a stamp of authentication, so consumers know an e-mail that appears to be from a bank really is from that



One Silly Question

"If Shammi Kapoor shouted Yahoo!, who shouted Google?"



"Me, who else!!"
Eshan Kaul, Jammu



"Shabhana Azmi."
Juhi Jadhav, Mumbai



"Hrithik."
Manvi Singh, Delhi



"I've no clue!"
Aditi Thale, Mumbai



"Bobby Deol!"
Eshan Singh, Dehradun